

CLEAR CUT Krishna Ella at Bharat Biotech's BSL-3 facility in Hyderabad

1.4

BILLION

TOTAL NO. OF COVID VACCINE DOSES ADMINISTERED TO THE ADULT POPULATION IN INDIA*

*as of Dec. 28, 2021

between five and 10 years to develop. Covid-19 threatened to rip through the globe, just as the Spanish Flu did a century ago. But if the virus had evolved, so had research and development in India and across the world on how to combat it speedily. Enter Ella and Adar.

Even before the pandemic struck, during a lecture in Bengaluru in December 2019, Ella had presciently warned of the dangers of such a virus and the need for preparation. Having worked on developing vaccines against the Zika and Chikungunya mini-pandemics, Ella had the foresight to build the infrastructure in his unit for such an eventuality. This included setting up one of the few top-notch Bio-safety Level-3 (BSL-3) laboratories available in the world to develop vaccines against dangerous viruses and the requisite manufacturing capacity to churn them out in large numbers.

So, when the WHO declared the Severe Acute Respiratory Syndrome-Coronavirus-2 (SARS-Cov-2) or Covid-19 for short as a global pandemic on March 11, 2020, Ella decided that he would take up the challenge of developing and manufacturing an indigenously made vaccine to combat it. As Ella put it, "For me, it was equal to India's nuclear moment—in the past only powerful countries had the